

Glossary: Important terms and Definitions

[v 1]

Accent and Dialect

- Accent: The way someone pronounces words.
 - Example: A person from London and a person from New York both speak English, but they have different accents.
- Dialect: A form of a language that includes different words, grammar, and pronunciation, often based on region.
 - Example: In some British dialects, people say “*I were there*” instead of “*I was there.*”

Variety (of English)

A variety of English is a specific form of English used in a certain place, group, or situation.

➤ Example: British English, American English, Indian English, and Nigerian English are all different varieties.

Variation

Variation means that people use different forms of a language depending on where they are, who they are, or when they live.

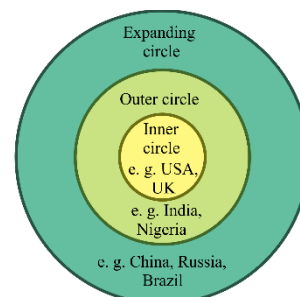
- Social variation: Language changes based on social group, such as age, class, gender, or background.
 - Example: Teenagers might say “*That’s lit!*”, while older people might say “*That’s great!*”
- Regional variation: Differences in language based on geography or location.
 - Example: In the UK, people in the north might say “*bairn*” for child; in the south, they say “*kid.*” Through the British Empire, English has made contact with hundreds of languages – local forms have developed and come to be accepted.
- Temporal (time) variation: Language changes over time.
 - Example: People used to say “*thou art*”, but today we say “*you are.*” *Knight* was once pronounced very similarly to DE *Knecht* – meaning and pronunciation changed over time.
- Situational variation: We speak differently depending on the situation or who we talk to.
 - Example: You say “*Hi!*” to a friend, but “*Good morning*” to a teacher or customer. Your teachers mark *ain’t* or even *isn’t* as wrong in formal language.
- Individual variation: Personal style or habit of each individual speaker.
 - Example: You might say “*I was literally dying of laughter.*”, but your friend might find the use of ‘literally’ wrong and instead prefer “*That was pretty funny.*”

Importance of Englishes for Global Communication

Frequently, when people discuss varieties of English, they focus on whether the typical person from a country was born with the language grew up with English at home (ENL), learnt it from a limited number of social contexts (ESL) or 'only' as a school subject (EFL). Additionally, English is used as a *lingua franca*, particularly by ESL and EFL speakers. Many people consider ENL varieties are to be 'better' Englishes.

Term	Full Form	Who Uses It?	Where?	Purpose / Use
ENL	English as a Native Language	Native speakers (first language)	UK, USA, Canada, Australia, New Zealand	Everyday life: home, school, media, government
ESL	English as a Second Language	Non-native speakers living in countries where English plays an official or major role	India, Nigeria, South Africa, Philippines	Education, business, media, government – used alongside local languages
EFL	English as a Foreign Language	Learners in non-English-speaking countries	Germany, China, Brazil, Japan	Used mainly for travel, study, work, or media; not spoken in daily life
ELF	English as a Lingua Franca	Speakers of different native languages using English to communicate	International settings (business, academia, online)	Cross-cultural communication without native speakers involved

In terms of absolute numbers, the 'Inner Circle'/ENL varieties are, however, the smallest group. They are greatly surpassed by Outer Circle/ESL and Expanding Circle/EFL Englishes.



Language change

Language change means that the way people speak and write changes over time. New words are added, meanings shift, and grammar can evolve (temporal variation). It only becomes a problem for understanding when varieties of different groups of speakers grow apart over time because they do not communicate frequently (different job, different regions, different ages, etc.)

► Example 1: The word "*mouse*" now also means a computer tool, not just an animal (new words invented within one technical field)

► Example 2: You know what a million and a billion are. But do you know what 20 lakh or 5 crore are? (Indian names for 100,000 and 10 million)